



DESERT

Extreme lack of rain and soils for sustained plant growth creates deserts, which at present account for about a third of Earth's landscapes, although this proportion is increasing. The largest desert is the African Sahara.

RATTLESNAKE

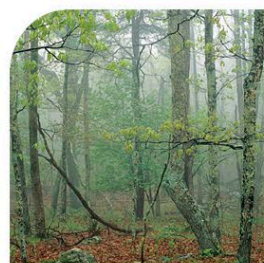


TROPICAL FOREST

The richest wildlife habitats on land are found in the forests of the tropics — Earth's hottest areas, which lie by the equator. Their numerous ecosystems are important yet increasingly vulnerable biodiversity hotspots.



STRAWBERRY POISON-DART FROG



TEMPERATE FOREST

Temperate environments lie between the tropics and the polar regions. The influence of both tropical and polar air masses promotes vast forests with considerable biodiversity. However, clearing by humans has greatly reduced their extent.

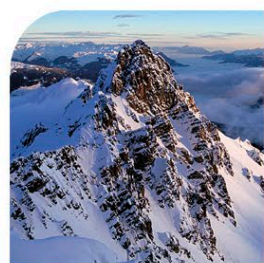
RED DEER



CONIFEROUS FOREST

Coniferous forest trees, such as redwoods, spruce, and fir, belong to an ancient plant group and are the world's toughest trees. Evergreen with small leaves, they thrive where few other trees can, in cold areas and in mountain ranges.

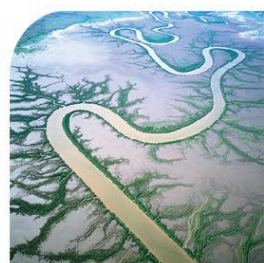
BROWN BEAR



MOUNTAINS

Reaching as high as 9 km (5½ miles) above sea level, Earth's mountains are home to many different environments. A single mountain can rise from temperate woodland up to arctic conditions as the climate changes with altitude.

PEREGRINE FALCON



RIVERS AND WETLAND

A wide range of animal and plant life thrives in Earth's rivers and lakes. Landscapes saturated with water, either permanently or seasonally, form distinctive wetlands, where areas of open water mix with dense vegetation.

DRAGONFLY



CORAL REEF

Coral reefs develop from the skeletons of marine organisms in shallow, sunlit tropical waters. Supporting an immense variety of life, they are the rainforests of the aquatic world.



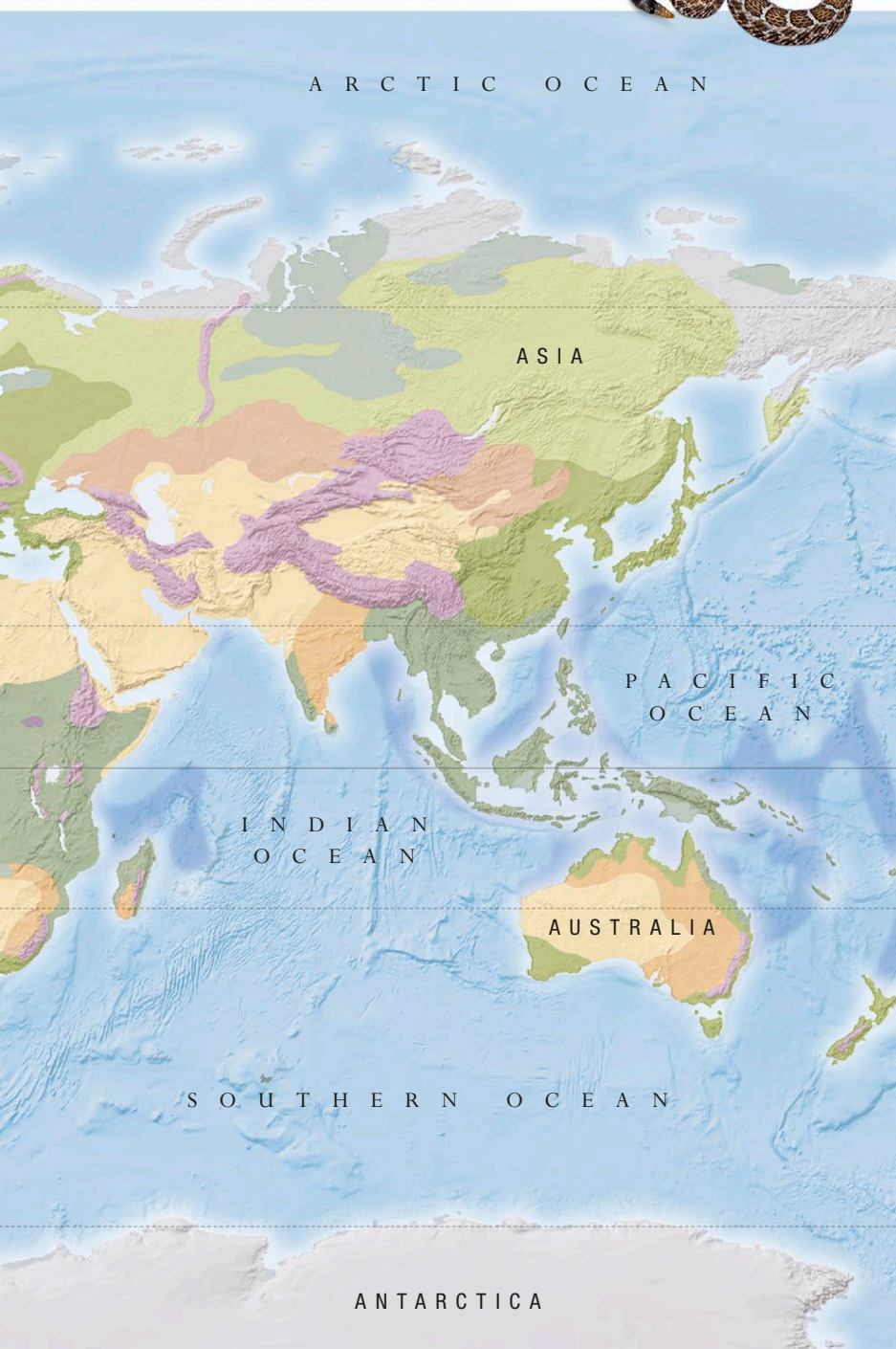
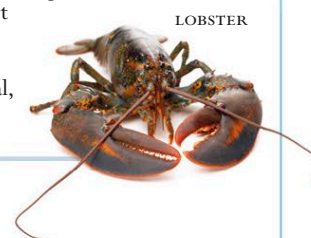
YELLOW TANG FISH



OCEANS

Life in oceans is found at all levels, from the sunlit surface to the deepest depths. Covering two-thirds of the planet, oceans form the largest continuous habitat on Earth and support very varied life forms — from microscopic plankton to the largest living mammal, the blue whale.

LOBSTER



POLAR REGIONS

The Arctic and Antarctic experience extreme seasons, with 24-hour daylight in summer and perpetual darkness in winter. Dominated by snow and ice, and with vast, dry areas of polar desert, both are highly vulnerable to climate change.

ROCKHOPPER PENGUIN

